

SH.2 Reference Check Form

One sheet per reference. Work down the script, write the answers where they fall, then finish the verification section — the part most owner-builders skip and later wish they had not.

Template for general reference — have your attorney review before use. Not legal advice.

Call. Don't email.

Three references minimum, all from the past year, all on work like yours. You hear hesitation on the phone that never shows up in an email, and a coached reference is far harder to fake out loud. Weekday evenings, 6–8 PM.

Subcontractor / company: _____ Trade: _____

Reference name: _____ Phone: _____

Their project — city: _____ Date & time called: _____

Reference is a: ☐ Homeowner ☐ General contractor ☐ Supplier

THE CALL

Open with this

"Hi, my name is _____. I'm building a house in _____ and I'm considering _____ for the _____ work. They gave me your name as a reference — do you have five minutes for ten quick questions?"

Listen, don't just record. The pause before question 10 tells you more than the answer does, and generic praise with no specific story means the reference barely remembers the job.

1. What work did they do for you, and when?

2. Was your job about the same size and scope as mine?

3. Did they start on the day they said they would?

☐ Yes ☐ No

4. Did they finish when they said they would?

☐ Yes ☐ No

5. Did the work pass inspection the first time?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not permitted work

6. Was the final price close to the quote? What changed?

7. When something changed, did they price it in writing *before* doing the work?

☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Nothing changed

8. What went wrong on the job, and how did they handle it?

9. How was communication — did they return calls and keep you posted?

10. Would you hire them again?

☐ Yes, without hesitation ☐ Yes, with reservations ☐ No

11. Anything you wish you'd known before you hired them?

VERIFICATION — DO NOT TAKE THEIR WORD FOR IT

References tell you how someone works; this tells you whether they are allowed to. Licensing, workers'-comp exemptions and lien records are set by state and county — look yours up before checking a box.

License lookup

Licensing agency / board: _____ Phone or website: _____

License #: _____ Class / trade: _____ Date checked: _____

Status: ☐ Current ☐ Expired ☐ None on file ☐ Not required here

Class covers my scope: ☐ Yes ☐ No

Board complaints or discipline: ☐ None found ☐ Found (see notes)

Insurance certificate

Certificate came from: ☐ Carrier ☐ Agent ☐ The contractor (weakest)

GL carrier: _____ Limit \$: _____ Expires: _____

Workers' comp carrier: _____ Expires: _____

☐ Called the carrier or agent and confirmed the policy is active

☐ Asked to be named as additional insured

Lien and legal history

County recorder / clerk searched: _____ Date: _____

Liens, lawsuits or judgments against them: ☐ None found ☐ Found

Liens they filed on past jobs: ☐ None found ☐ Found

RESULT

This reference is: ☐ Clear ☐ A concern ☐ Disqualifying

Notes — quotes, hesitations, anything that did not add up

Checked by: _____ Date: _____